Error clinic: tense consistency, punctuation and common slips

Understand it

Every writer has a few personal errors that come back again and again. Fixing these three or four errors is the fastest way to move from 6.5 to 7 in grammar.

Read your essay once for content, then a second time only for your error list. Do not try to check everything at once.

The rules

- Keep one tense in a paragraph unless the time changes. Describe a past chart in the past tense all the way.
- A comma splice joins two sentences with only a comma: wrong. Use a full stop, a semicolon, or a linking word.
- Commas: after an opening phrase (In addition,), around extra information, before but / and / so when joining two clauses.
- Check this list: subject-verb agreement, articles, plural -s, tenses, spelling of common words (environment, government, necessary, definitely).

All the words and forms you need

Sentence errors	comma splice · fragment (no main verb) · run-on sentence
Verb errors	tense consistency · subject-verb agreement · wrong form after modals (must to go)
Noun errors	missing article · missing plural -s · uncountable with -s (informations)
Word choice	make / do · say / tell · economic / economical · affect / effect
Spelling	environment · government · necessary · beginning · definitely · accommodation · business · believe
Punctuation	comma after a linking word at the start · no comma before that · apostrophe for possession only

Where you use it

Writing: Spend the last 3 minutes reading only for these errors.

Speaking: Record yourself and find the one error you repeat most.

Reading: Not applicable, but good punctuation helps you read long sentences.

More examples

- Prices rose sharply; however, demand stayed high.

- The government has introduced a new law.
- Many people believe that cities are too crowded.
- This will affect the environment, and the effect will last.
- Young people need advice about money.
- The company's profits increased.

Common mistakes

WRONG	RIGHT
✗ Sales rose in 2010, they fell in 2011.	✓ Sales rose in 2010 but fell in 2011.
✗ The government have decided.	✓ The government has decided.
✗ It is nessecary to enviroment.	✓ It is necessary for the environment.

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. Record a 1-minute answer about your hometown. Listen and find your most common error.
2. Talk about your last holiday, using past tenses only.
3. Describe your daily routine with he / she.
4. What do you make and what do you do at home?
5. Tell me something your teacher said to you.

Writing practice

Take your last essay, list your 3 most repeated errors, and correct every example of them.

Practice

1. Fix the comma splice: Cities grow fast, they need more homes.

2. Fix the tense: In 2015 sales fall and then rise.

3. Spell correctly: goverment

4. Spell correctly: enviroment

5. Add commas: However it was too late.

6. Fix: The people is angry.

Answers

1. Cities grow fast, so they need more homes.
2. In 2015 sales fell and then rose.
3. government
4. environment
5. However, it was too late.
6. The people are angry.